

Instructions For Participant

Business Development Manager

AC-EXS® Interview Simulation - Internal

Name:

(For use by one participant only)

Date:



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Business Development Manager Instructions For Participant

Introduction

You are the newly appointed Strategic Development Director with Kashai Incorporated plc (usually referred to as Kashai or Kashai Inc pronounced *cash-ay*). Your task is to conduct a meeting with Sam Gray, a Business Development Manager within your team.

The meeting had been arranged by your predecessor, Amanda Stratford who left Kashai to take up a position with a competitor and thus no hand-over was possible and you have not met her. You have learnt that Amanda had arranged a meeting with Sam Gray upon the receipt of some information (attached) from Matt Stephenson, Group Business Development Director with responsibility for the three smallest subsidiaries within Kashai, known internally as WWHA. This information relates to Sam and a project Sam appears to be involved with. When Matt heard of your appointment and imminent arrival he was keen for you to honour the meeting as he considered it to be of utmost importance. Your personal secretary has also furnished you with some data about Sam and the team's performance.

Your Task

This exercise allows you 45 minutes to prepare for the interview (during which time you may make notes if you wish) and 30 minutes for the interview itself.

PLEASE DO NOT TURN OVER UNTIL TOLD TO DO SO

Amanda Stratford

From: Matt Stephenson
To: Amanda Stratford
Date: 3 days ago
Subject: Sam Gray

It frustrates me to have to email you rather than talk to you but I have been unable to contact you on the telephone and this is a matter of such importance that I want to raise it with you as soon as I can.

As you know, we have a strong reputation in the North-West for reliability and quality and the vision for WWHA is based on these attributes, yet the actions of your staff are threatening to put these at risk. I was approached by Sam Gray a few months ago in relation to research for a re-focus within Kashai to create a global Kashai brand. Whilst this alarmed me as it has not been communicated within the business and because my three businesses have very distinct brands for good reason, Sam assured me that it was simply a research project.

I am now outraged that this global re-branding appears to be underway without anyone communicating this to me. Sam has scheduled in-store visits for a firm of retail re-fitters to take measurements next week. Even more alarming is the fact that had I not happened to have a conversation with an old friend working in the industry locally, who asked me whether he should start to get concerned about the new vision and branding for my stores, I would never have found out about it! Apparently he had heard a rumour from some re-fitters who had been working at one of his outlets.

It is preposterous to implement such a strategy and to do so without the common decency to communicate that to us or even involve us in a consultation exercise is leading me to question the integrity and judgement of your department. Our previously good working relationship is the only reason I have not gone straight to other Board members on this matter, yet I shall be forced to do so unless you take remedial action immediately.

I look forward to hearing your response,

Matt

Matt Stephenson

Group Business Development Director

WR Opticians, Webb & Holmes Eye Care, Abbots Horton Opticians

email: Matthew.Stephenson@kashai.com

PRIVATE & CONFIDENTIAL

Personnel Record

Name: Sam Gray

Role: Business Development Manager

Reports to: Strategic Development Director (ie you)

Department: Business Development.
Responsible for the overall vision and direction of business growth across Kashai Inc.

Description of Role: The Business Development Manager has responsibility for leading a group of six Business Development Executives. Together they have responsibility for implementing the direction of business growth set by the Board across the Group, supporting and enhancing the performance of the operating companies through new business growth, sales and marketing. This team work within Kashai Inc – Corporate. They are not positioned within the subsidiaries; rather providing a service to all operating companies.

History

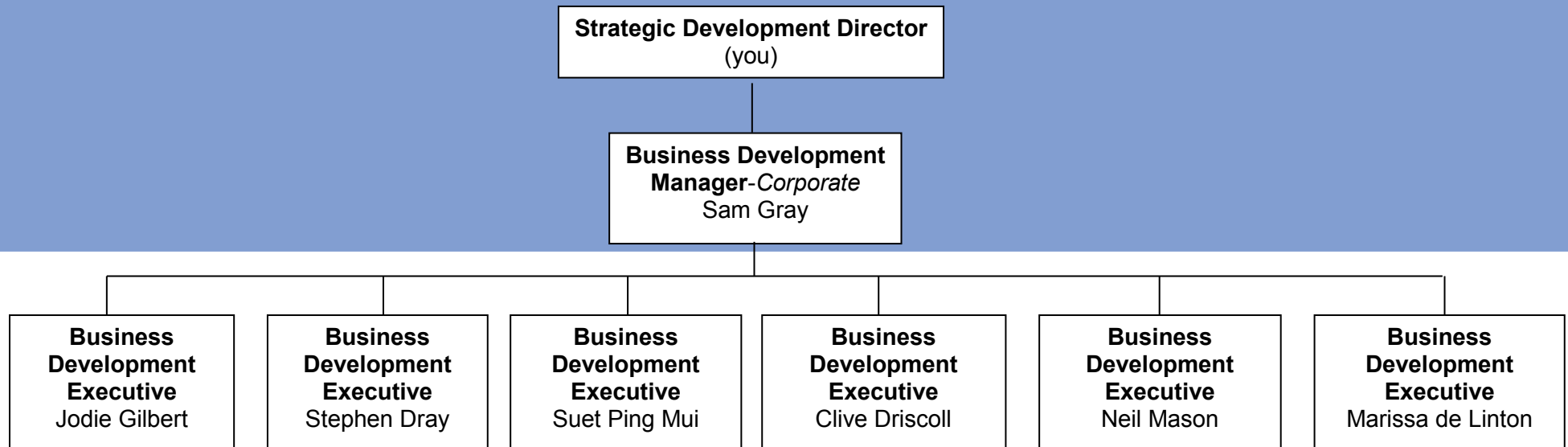
Sam Gray has been in position for 18 months and was previously with the Fontessa Group, a large fashion clothing retail organisation, as an Assistant Business Development Manager.

Notes from Previous Line Manager

During the first 12 months with Kashai Sam was full of the enthusiasm and drive, the same qualities that Sam had exhibited during the initial recruitment interviews. In the past 6 months Sam's level of enthusiasm seems to have been waning and recently Sam's contribution to the department has lessened significantly. Conversations to motivate Sam have not been successful and Sam continues to perform at a satisfactory but not outstanding level. I have spoken with Sam about it but he/she failed to understand my concerns, stating that he/she thought it was better for Kashai. Sam tends to have lots of ideas for the future but is unable to back these up with detailed plans and thus he/she lacks credibility. In recent meetings I have failed to uncover the cause of Sam's change in performance and I've noticed that Sam has stopped sharing ideas with me.

Sam always retains a high standard of professionalism and has extensive knowledge of the industry through continued research and conference attendance. In the two 360° feedback evaluations which have taken place since joining Kashai, Sam has received higher than average ratings from the team, across most areas.

Business Development Team – Corporate



Background

Kashai is the third largest optician in the UK with a nationwide network of 375 retail stores and a turnover of £281,250,000. It was started at the end of World War One by Thomas Langguth, a German emigrant who later changed the family and business name to 'Langridge' to avoid the prevailing anti-German sentiment. He built a successful business with a solid reputation for providing clinical excellence and traditional service to a loyal customer base. The last member of the Langridge family, Albert, retired 5 years ago as Chairman when the Company was floated on the Stock Market. It was at this time that the new Chief Executive, Brian Mather, presided over the re-launch of the Company as Kashai Incorporated plc, although the core business with 200 stores retained the Langridge & Son identity.

After a series of acquisitions, which took place approximately 2 years either side of the flotation, Kashai now has the following retail optical subsidiaries:

- Langridge & Son.
- Q-Eyes.
- WR Opticians.
- Webb & Holmes Eye Care.
- Abbots Horton Opticians.
- Jordan Capital Eye Style.

The last financial year ended 3 months ago. Whilst the Company recorded a modest increase in profits, the share price slumped to an all-time low, reducing the market valuation by around 30%. The adverse publicity that has recently surrounded the organisation has been compounded by the apparent failure of Kashai's '8 is Great' campaign, which was sponsored personally by Brian Mather. Its focus was on achieving a net profit margin of 8%, this being simply net profit as a percentage of sales and a key performance indicator for the business. Whilst the Board has for some time been considering the options for implementing widespread change, there is no doubt that the negative publicity and pressure from institutional shareholders has acted as a catalyst.

The Operating Companies

1. Langridge & Son

Langridge & Son, still the flagship core business within Kashai, employs about 2,925 people and operates a network of 200 stores across the UK. Most of last year's increase in sales and profit came from the five new stores, which were opened in the Midlands and Scotland. Due to its excellent reputation for quality and long-established presence on the high street, the Company has built a loyal customer base particularly among the over 45s age group and pensioners.

2 Q-Eyes

Q-Eyes was acquired 3 years ago and operates a network of 111 stores located across the UK but principally concentrated in the North-East, Yorkshire, Humberside and Scotland.

For the last financial year, this subsidiary recorded sales of £85.3 million. Virtually all of the increase in sales and profit came from the three new stores, which were opened in Leeds and Glasgow.

The retail formula at Q-Eyes has not changed substantially for over a decade when the previous owners decided to focus the business on providing a faster service than competitors to differentiate itself in the marketplace. As a result, the business has found its own niche.

3 Jordan Capital Eye Style

Jordan Capital Eye Style was acquired 4 years ago from its entrepreneurial founder, Adam Jordan.

Jordan Capital Eye Style now employs about 287 people and operates 15 large stores in London and the South-East. For the last financial year, this subsidiary recorded sales of £14,196,000, an increase of 16.75% on the previous year. The net profit contribution of just over £1,038,000 represented an increase of 10.8%. About two thirds of the increase in sales and profit came from two new stores, with the rest generated from organic growth.

The average turnover of each store is about £940,000 (the largest in Kashai) and many operate from two floors and have three testing rooms. All have access to good, efficient IT operating systems.

4 WR Opticians, Webb & Holmes Eye Care and Abbots Horton Opticians

Taken together, these regional opticians operate 49 stores in the North-West of England and they were acquired in stages just before the flotation. For the last financial year, their net profit contribution of just over £1,132,000 represented an increase of 5.74%. About 80% of the increase in sales and profit came from three new stores, with the rest generated from organic growth.

In effect, Matt Stephenson manages these Companies in his role as Group Business Development Director. Until recently, he has adopted an 'if it ain't broke, don't fix it' strategy with the other Directors. His faith is borne out by last year's figures, which indicate steady if not exciting progress.

As individual entities, these three subsidiaries command a strong local reputation for reliability and quality, although customer feedback seems to suggest that standards of service have fallen recently. This has coincided with higher staff turnover figures, particularly amongst Optical Assistants.

These businesses have all focused successfully on meeting the eye care needs of families by providing competitively priced products in traditional surroundings. However, although the stores are well maintained, they have not been re-fitted since joining the Group. The image is starting to look tired. Footfall has fallen in the past 3 months and this has been reflected in poor sales performance.